to be at Missamari near Tezpur in Assam. 11 Infantry Brigade was given the responsibility of looking after the vast area comprising the Subansiri, Siang and Lohit Frontier Divisions. The HQ of 4 Infantry Division was set up in Tezpur. Special trains carrying the troops began to arrive in Missamari. 1/9 Gorkha Rifles, who would subsequently become the vanguard of 7 Infantry Brigade, arrived on 29 November and was soon followed by 9 Punjab.

Normally, an infantry brigade would be made up of three or four battalions (each comprising seven to eight hundred men), all of which function under the Brigade HQ as a cohesive body in mutual support of each other. In the initial move to NEFA, 7 Brigade had two battalions, while 11 Brigade consisted of just 2 Rajput that was being commanded by Lieutenant Colonel Maha Singh Rikh. Travelling on special trains, the Rajputs with their surface transport had reached Missamari from Subathu, from where they proceeded to Lokhra. As part of their induction, they then spent the next few months doing jungle training while getting acclimatized to the conditions in Assam which were a far cry from those in Punjab.

From Missamari the battalion then moved even further east to Tezu, which would become its rear headquarters. In small batches, the men would then be airlifted from the small airfield at Tezu to the advanced landing ground (ALG) at Walong. The rough landing strip on the left bank of the Lohit River could take Twin Otters apart from the Mi-4 helicopters while the workhorse Dakotas used the landing strip as a drop zone (DZ) to drop supplies using reusable parachutes. The only troops ahead of 2 Rajput were a section of 2 Assam Rifles at Kibithu. Despite the chronic shortage of equipment and supplies and the near primitive living conditions, the morale of the troops was extremely high.

Even though almost two decades had gone by since the end of World War II, there were men, now senior JCOs, in the infantry battalions deployed in NEFA who had operated with or seen Chinese troops in action. Though Chiang Kai-shek’s Kuomintang troops had mainly operated in the China-Burma-India theatre under the command of the American General ‘Vinegar Joe’ Stilwell and had been restricted to the northern extremities of the Naga Patkai ranges, Chinese troops were not very highly regarded by the Indians who, as we’ve noted earlier, referred to them as ‘afeemchis’.

The mad rush to send the three brigades east towards the end of November served no operational purpose whatsoever. In a way it was typical of the new manner of functioning in Army HQ. In various offices in